

**Cultural Characteristics of Zhiguai Narrative Texts in Youyang
Zazu and the Study of Late Tang Cultural History:
A Case Study of Nuogao Ji and Zhi Nuogao**

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We hereby recommend that the Capstone Project by Ms. Wang Minqian, entitled “Cultural Characteristics of Zhiguai Narrative Texts in Youyang Zazu and the Study of Late Tang Cultural History: A Case Study of Nuogao Ji and Zhi Nuogao,” be accepted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the Master of Arts in Digital History in Global Asia.

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Abstract

This study examines the cultural characteristics of zhiguai narratives in *Youyang Zazu*, with particular focus on the sections *Nuogao Ji* and *Zhi Nuogao*. Through narrative analysis, textual comparison, and cultural-historical interpretation, the thesis explores how Duan Chengshi constructed supernatural narratives that reflected the cultural psychology, historiographical consciousness, and social imagination of the late Tang period. The study analyzes narrative gaps, representations of anomalous phenomena, and the interaction between reality and the supernatural. It argues that these narratives not only preserve the literary tradition of zhiguai writing but also demonstrate a tendency toward transforming the anomalous into the normative, thereby revealing the complex relationship between literature, historiography, and cultural perception in late Tang China.

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1. Introduction

As an important component of social culture, literary works have consistently occupied a significant position in the study of cultural history. Whether in literary history research concerning the developmental process of literary activities or within the theoretical framework of the New Cultural History school, which has been profoundly influenced by literary theory, literary works constitute one of the key elements reflecting social culture. In cultural historical studies, alongside material cultural history—which focuses on specific material products—there also exists the study of spiritual and intellectual cultural history, which concerns the collective thought, knowledge, and culture of society as a whole. If material cultural history relies upon tangible material artifacts and the cultures generated and developed through them, then in the study of spiritual cultural history, various artistic and literary activities, such as music, literature, and works of art, become major objects of inquiry.

Throughout the development of ancient Chinese historiography, there existed a persistent characteristic of the convergence of literature and history. Awareness of the distinctiveness of literature and history can be traced back to the Han dynasty, after which the unique identity of literature gradually developed and began to diverge from historiography. In other words, from the perspective of classification, literature emerged later than historiography; consequently, early literary activities naturally possessed historical characteristics. Meanwhile, in the realm of history, the influence of social culture upon textual tendencies in turn shaped both methods of historical recording and historiographical concepts. For example, during the Wei, Jin, and Northern and Southern Dynasties periods, the development of Daoism amid social instability led people naturally to turn toward religion in

search of inner peace. As a result, *qingtian* flourished. In textual representation, this phenomenon manifested itself through strong religious and metaphysical overtones, as people consciously or unconsciously employed such concepts to interpret problems encountered in real life. Hu Yinglin commented on the prevalence of *zhiguai* writing during this period as follows: “魏、晋好长生,故多灵变之说;齐、梁弘释典,故多因果之谈。” Zhang Qingmin cites a record from “列异传” concerning Qin’s domination of the realm in order to illustrate the relationship between the *zhiguai* narrative tradition and real-world politics during the Wei and Jin periods:

秦穆公时,陈仓人掘地得异物;其形不类狗,亦不似羊,众莫能名。牵以献穆公,道逢二童子。童子曰:“此名为‘媼’,常在地下食死人脑。若欲杀之,以柏插其头。”媼复曰:“彼二童子,名为‘陈宝’;得雄者王,得雌者霸。”陈仓人舍媼,逐二童子,童子化为雉,飞入平林。陈仓人告穆公,穆公发徒大猎,果得其雌。又化为石,置之汧渭之间。至文公,为立祠,名“陈宝”。雄飞南集,今南阳雒县其地也。秦欲表其符,故以名县。每陈仓祠时,有赤光长十余丈,从雒县来,入“陈宝”祠中,有声如雄鸡。

This passage clearly demonstrates that Qin’s unification of the realm was regarded as the fulfillment of the Mandate of Heaven. It reflects an obvious narrative tendency to interpret real-world politics through metaphysical discourse. Such narrative tendencies during the Wei, Jin, and Northern and Southern Dynasties periods also profoundly influenced contemporary traditions of historical compilation. Owing to widespread belief in concepts such as *chenwei* prophecy and apocryphal learning, historical works of the Wei and Jin periods were filled with descriptions of omens, auspicious and inauspicious signs, and supernatural portents. Consequently, when historians of the early Tang dynasty undertook the compilation of official histories, they faced a historiographical structure in which reality and

the supernatural were deeply intertwined, making it difficult to locate records that were entirely objective and materialist in character.

The historiographical tradition of “recording history with a truthful brush” was not firmly established until the Northern Song dynasty, when Ouyang Xiu revised the *New Book of Tang* and the *New History of the Five Dynasties*. Prior to this period, due to limitations in historical materials, the compilers of the *Old Book of Tang* were compelled to draw upon unofficial histories, family histories, and even certain literary works in order to supplement missing content. As a dynasty marked by unprecedented prosperity in both culture and state power, the Tang dynasty also possessed a strong material foundation for religious propagation. Consequently, for Tang people who had long been influenced by various forms of religious discourse, supernatural forces did not seem far removed from everyday life. This perception deeply influenced the writings of certain unofficial recorders. Authors of miscellaneous histories, anecdotal records, and *zazu* miscellanies believed that these inexplicable supernatural powers and phenomena were themselves part of the real world, and that recording them constituted a reflection of reality. Among them, Duan Chengshi, regarded as one of the foremost pioneers of *zhiguai* fiction, produced his representative work, *Youyang Zazu*. Later generations evaluated this text in the following manner:

“题顾元庆《博异志跋》(伪)云:‘唐人小史中,多造奇艳事为传志,自是一代才情,非后世可及。然怪深幽眇,无如《诺皋》、《博异》二种,此其厥体中韩昌黎、李长吉也。’王文濡《说库提要·诺皋记》云:‘唐人小说颇多幽渺怪异,是编尤觉离奇。理想之空灵,才情之恣肆,堪与《博异记》并传。’《诺皋》之记,皆以瑰丽警兀之笔述天地之奇,篇幅虽大都不及《玄怪》、《传奇》之长,然巧为幻设,工事藻绘,自非六朝志怪可比,至尽委曲之韵者亦多,则俨然传奇之体。昔人之誉,非虚美也。《四库提要》则言,唐世小说,本书最传,为古今瞩目,‘自唐以来,推为小说之翘楚,莫或废也。’”

From these evaluations, it is evident that *Youyang Zazu* was regarded not only as the pinnacle of Tang-dynasty *zhiguai* fiction, but also that the five sections of “Nuo Gao” were considered among the finest supernatural narratives within the work.

As a narrative tradition within classical Chinese fiction, *zhiguai* narratives not only convey how early peoples understood the world, but also preserve and transmit important aspects of folk tales and folk culture. In the folktale-type index compiled by Ding Naitong and others, folk narratives are distilled into concise plot sequences through careful attention to narrative structure, thereby enabling even highly complex stories to be systematically compared with one another. Their work, *A Type Index of Chinese Folktales*, provides valuable reference points both for understanding narrative structures and for employing large language models (LLMs) in classification tasks.

A review of scholarship on *Youyang Zazu* reveals three major directions of research. The first concerns the analysis and study of textual variants across different texts, such as Liu Chuanhong’s philological examination of variant and compound characters in *Youyang Zazu*. The second concerns textual and edition studies, a field represented by scholars such as Fang Nansheng and Pan Jianguo, whose research traces the earliest printed edition of the work back to the Southern Song dynasty. The third direction focuses on narratological characteristics and cultural traditions within *Youyang Zazu*. Examples include Lai Chuntao’s study of the work’s development and inheritance of Wei-Jin and Six Dynasties tales of transients, Hang Xinyi’s research on narrative gaps within the text, and comparative studies between the story “Ye Xian” in *Zhi Nuogao* and the Cinderella tale, among others. These studies, however, have often been constrained either by limitations of scope or by technological restrictions. Most tend to focus on one or several representative stories for

localized discussion. Their range of inquiry is generally limited: scholars either select several passages of particular interest for close reading, conduct diachronic studies of a certain type of text, or examine the narrative features of a small group of stories within the book from a synchronic perspective. Rarely are these analyses integrated into a broader, systematic whole. In light of this research situation, the present study attempts to digitize and classify the text, and further seeks to employ visualization methods to facilitate objective and direct comparison of the data, thereby enabling both researchers and non-specialists alike to intuitively grasp the narrative characteristics and cultural-historical significance of the work.

2. Database Description

The data component of this study seeks to address three primary issues. First, it aims to clean the raw texts in order to establish a reliable original corpus. Second, it seeks to classify the texts accurately and select those texts and categories that best meet the needs of the research. Third, it focuses on data visualization and platform construction.

Because the original texts were written in Classical Chinese, and because the semantic diversity of the Chinese language itself can significantly affect the judgments of large language models (LLMs), solving these problems requires the fulfillment of two prerequisites. The first is the availability of highly reliable annotated texts that can serve as references, enabling the LLM to infer proper punctuation and classification in the original text through modern Chinese annotations. The second is a highly clear and executable classification logic. By composing Skills documents, these problems were divided into a

series of smaller tasks, and prompts were continuously refined in order to guide the LLM in completing them. Overall, the first and second issues were divided into four tasks:

1. Compare two OCR-processed raw-text documents. If the passages are completely identical, they are treated as “verified texts”; if they do not overlap, they are left unprocessed.
2. For raw text 1 and raw text 2 containing annotations, identify text in designated formats as annotations, distinguish the “verified text” from the annotations, and generate separate documents for the verified text and the annotations.
3. Treat the verified-text document as the target document and, with reference to the annotation document, segment all text within the target document into paragraphs.
4. Classify the verified-text document and provide detailed classification criteria. These criteria must include classification logic, categories, classification objectives, classification cases, and output results.

Through this process, the original data underwent systematic classification. The final output consisted of tables organized according to narrative structure and descriptive object. Based on the contents of these tables, an SQLite database was constructed and subsequently visualized. At this stage, the data foundation for the textual study was completed.

For non-specialist audiences, the database established above was further organized through front-end web UI design principles. Using prompts and artificial intelligence, a front-end webpage was constructed. The final product achieved a complete webpage structure, including introductions to both the research object and the research themes. Several progressively engaging stories were used to encourage non-specialists to explore the site

further, while searchable tables of supernatural beings and supernatural phenomena were provided through the support of the backend SQL database.

Based on the preliminary classification and organization, it became evident that the key contents of *Youyang Zazu* highly overlapped with the research objects selected in this study. Given that the “Five *Nuogao* Chapters” contain the highest proportion of records related to the research objects—and that supernatural elements account for 100 percent of the content in each of these five chapters, which are also regarded as possessing the highest artistic value—these texts were selected as the core objects of discussion. Since this study examines the relationship between narrative structure and cultural history, and because a portion of the target texts does not strictly conform to narratological definitions of narratively meaningful texts, the LLM was instructed, through the provision of definitions and examples, to filter the materials and conduct a secondary classification of the selected texts. In this way, the final categories contained coherent plots, conformed to the definition of narrative texts, and could each be restricted to a single category, thereby facilitating subsequent discussion and research. Ultimately, 95 valuable texts were selected from a total of 147 texts and classified into twelve categories.

3. Interpretation of Narrative Texts: Taking *Nuogao Ji* and *Zhi Nuogao* as Examples

3.1 Definition of Narrative Texts and the Basis for Their Selection

In textual analysis, a common misunderstanding is the assumption that narrative is equivalent to the text itself. In fact, narrative and narrative texts concern a more abstract level of meaning. Narrative texts are often not inherently interesting. Tong Qingbing points out that

“narrative works are literary works in which the narrative function is primary. ... The analysis of narrative works is in fact an analysis of the entire process of narrative activity, conducted on three levels. First, one analyzes narrative content, namely the relationship between narrative activity and objective social life; this involves examining how elements of the external world enter literature and acquire literary form through narrative discourse....” From Tong Qingbing’s description, it can be seen that narrative texts are closely connected with reality.

During the development of narratology, Structuralism and Russian Formalism once occupied dominant positions in Western narratological studies. In compiling *A Dictionary of Narratology*, Gerald Prince identifies two opposing viewpoints under the entry “narratology.” One, represented by Tzvetan Todorov, argues that narratology studies the universal characteristics of narrative, especially the universal structure of stories, without regard to narrative medium. In other words, text, video, and images may all become objects of narratological inquiry. The opposing view, represented by Gérard Genette, holds that narratology should concern only narrative acts mediated through language, that is, narrative literature. From this perspective, narratology neither attempts to generalize stories themselves nor concerns itself with the meaning of stories; rather, it studies narrative discourse as reflected in the relationship between story and narrative text.

These definitions of narratology emerged in the mid-twentieth century, and after nearly sixty years of development, narratology has undergone continual revision and reflection. Broadly speaking, narratology focuses on the narrative dimension of stories. Narrators, narrative modes, narrative structures, narrative techniques, and narrative objects may all serve as objects of narratological study. But what, precisely, constitutes literary

narrative? Narrative clearly concerns the story told by a narrator, and this process itself may be regarded as the simplest and most fundamental form of narrative. Tong Qingbing summarizes the essential characteristics of literary narrative in two aspects: first, “the content of narrative consists of processes of social-life events, namely human social actions and their results”; second, “narrative is the fictionality of discourse.” He therefore defines literary narrative as “the discursive fictionalization of processes of social-life events.”

To put this more plainly, the sentence “Books are the ladder of human progress” is not a narrative, because it contains neither plot nor a process of telling, nor does it express an event. Although it is philosophically meaningful, it does not constitute a narrative. By contrast, “She took a bite of the apple,” while far less interesting in terms of literary appeal, genuinely narrates an event. Through this sentence, one or more events are connected together, thereby forming a story. From this perspective, the sentence unquestionably constitutes a narrative.

Accordingly, narrative texts may be defined as follows: “A narrative text should be a story-oriented text possessing such levels as plot, narrator, and narrative structure, and internally connecting one or more events.” Attention to narrative texts primarily concerns the category of narrative content. Narrative content refers to “the story content constituting the theme of a stretch of narrative discourse, namely the narrated story itself, including events, characters, settings, and so forth.” Tong Qingbing further notes:

“Traditional narrative literary creation often consciously or unconsciously presupposes a tacit understanding with its audience, requiring readers to believe that what is narrated is true. The epics, myths, and heroic legends transmitted orally among primitive clans, although largely fictional and strange in content, were accepted by members of the clan

as genuine historical facts. Later narrative literature inherited this psychological tradition. For example, marvelous and fantastical *chuanqi* tales written by Tang literati often explain at the end where the author heard the story, and sometimes even introduce the later circumstances of the characters, clearly hoping that readers would accept these bizarre stories as factual.”

The phenomenon described by Tong Qingbing is especially evident in *Youyang Zazu*.

Beyond the text itself, narrative also involves another crucial factor: the narrator. In common understanding, the most familiar distinction is that between reliable and unreliable narrators. From the reader’s overall perspective, a narrator is either entirely reliable or entirely unreliable. From the perspective of time, a narrator may be reliable at one moment and unreliable at another, but cannot simultaneously be both reliable and unreliable in the same sense. A reliable narrator implies that the narration is wholly trustworthy, whereas with an unreliable narrator, readers must evaluate the credibility of the discourse itself. The reliability of narrators often further involves the question of the hidden narrator. For example, in “Shexi,” the narrator “I” and Lu Xun as the author of the story together form a pair involving both an unreliable narrator and a reliable hidden narrator.

The distinction between narrators points toward two key elements in narratology: binary opposition and synchronic versus diachronic perspectives. Binary opposition was a category employed by Structuralist analysis in its attempt to interpret narrative structures. Its central premise is that binary oppositions universally exist within social and natural phenomena. In other words, binary oppositions possess distinctive socio-cultural characteristics: they are fluid and mutable, reflecting social culture while simultaneously being shaped by it. Consequently, analysis of binary oppositions within narrative texts can point toward the cultural-historical characteristics underlying the texts themselves.

Secondly, synchronic and diachronic characteristics may be understood as follows: the story itself is regarded as a whole, and when texts are analyzed from the perspective of Structuralist narratology, narrative is often treated as a cross-section in time. The historical evolution of the narrative is not considered; instead, attention is focused on the internal integrity of the narrative itself, that is, on synchronic and horizontal analysis rather than historical tracing. Yet for narrative-text studies conducted from the perspective of cultural history, although synchronic analysis remains important, one must ultimately return to the historical perspective in order to seek the causes behind the narrative's emergence. Thus, the selection and analysis of narrative texts within *Youyang Zazu* are deeply connected to the question of from what perspective Tang cultural history should be understood.

Lu Xun described the contents of *Youyang Zazu* in *A Brief History of Chinese Fiction* as follows: “.....或录秘书, 或叙异事, 仙佛人鬼以至动植, 弥不毕载, 以类相聚, 有如类书.....”

From this description, it is evident that the arrangement of most texts in *Youyang Zazu*, and even the recording methods of certain passages, resemble those of *leishu* encyclopedic compilations. *Leishu* refers to a type of traditional Chinese encyclopedic text in which materials are grouped according to thematic categories. Such works generally collect sentences and passages from various texts related to specific categories, resulting in highly miscellaneous content. Not every entry possesses strong narrative characteristics. This feature is most clearly reflected in “Guang Dongzhi” (“Extensive Accounts of Flora and Fauna”), in which almost no narrative texts appear. Instead, the passages merely describe particular objects; they contain no plot and do not connect events together. Consequently, when analyzing such texts, it is difficult to apply narratological methods, because they resist

meaningful classification. This also demonstrates that if binary opposition or synchronic and diachronic relations are employed as analytical entry points, then textual selection becomes especially necessary.

Li Jianguo points out that “成式首倡‘志怪小说’一词”, and further comments on the chapters within the work: “《天咫》、《玉格》、《壶史》、《盗侠》之属固已以幻丽见长, 而《诺皋》五篇尤称佳制。” From this, it is evident that *Youyang Zazu* possesses not only significant literary status, but also that its essence lies precisely within the “Five *Nuogao* Chapters,” namely *Nuogao Ji I*, *Nuogao Ji II*, *Zhi Nuogao I*, *Zhi Nuogao II*, and *Zhi Nuogao III*. Does this mean that the texts contained within these five chapters can simply be adopted directly for analysis? In fact, the answer is no. Taking *Nuogao Ji I* as an example, some stories within it still lack plot structures. For instance, several passages appearing at the very beginning of the chapter read as follows:

昆仑之墟, 帝之下都, 百神所在也。大荒中有灵山, 有十巫, 曰咸、即、盼、彭、姑、真、礼、抵、谢、罗, 从此升降。

汉竹宫用紫泥为坛, 天神下若流火, 玉饰器七千枚(一作枝), 舞女三百人。一曰汉祭天神用万二千杯, 养牛五岁, 重三千斤。

太一君讳腊, 天秩万二千石。

北斗魁第一星神名执阴, 第二星曰叶谥, 第三星曰视金, 第四星曰拒理, 第五星曰防作, 第六星曰开宝, 第七星曰招摇。

It can be seen that the passages above are descriptive texts lacking plot structure. Therefore, in the context of this discussion, such descriptive passages do not conform to the definition of narrative texts established earlier and must consequently be excluded. However, during the process of selection, there exists a category of texts that can easily be confused

with these purely descriptive passages, such as “Huabuzhu Spring” and “Dongxiang Reclining Stone” from *Nuogao Ji I*:

“华不注泉，齐顷公取水处，方圆百馀步。北齐时，有人以绳千尺沉石试之不穷，石出，赤如血，其人不久坐事死。

荆州永丰县东乡里有卧石一，长九尺六寸。其形似人体，青黄隐起，状若雕刻。境若旱，便齐手而举之，小举小雨，大举大雨。相传此石忽见于此，本长九尺，今加六寸矣。”

It is evident that these two passages in fact do contain plot elements, and that the texts connect one or more events together. Consequently, such passages should be included within the category of narrative texts. Based on this principle of classification, among the total of 147 entries in the Five *Nuogao* Chapters, 95 were ultimately selected as narrative texts suitable for further discussion and analysis.

3.2 Classification of Narrative Texts in *Nuogao Ji* and *Zhi Nuogao*

In *Morphology of the Folktale*, Vladimir Propp summarized four principles of folktales based on the functions of characters within stories:

1. The functions of characters are stable and constant elements within stories, regardless of who performs them or how they are performed.
2. For folktales, the number of functions is limited.
3. The sequence of functions is always fixed.
4. All folktales belong to a single structural type.

Under such requirements, events within a story can often be highly generalized into certain descriptive statements. For example: “the hero destroys the villain,” or “the villain is punished,” and so forth. However, for Chinese folktales, matters are not so simple. If one

reads Ding Naitong's *A Type Index of Chinese Folktales*, it becomes evident that Chinese folktale events are relatively fragmented. Taking Type 503E in *A Type Index of Chinese Folktales* as an example, its plot may begin with "a tree spirit repays kindness," while Type 503EV may closely follow with "a tree spirit becoming a spouse." This sequence, in turn, resembles the story structure of Type 555A, "The Grateful Dead." From this, it can be seen that the degree of intricacy and complexity involved in the classification of narrative texts is far greater than in Propp's system. Some stories may contain multiple plot developments.

“新罗有第一贵族金哥，其宅北忽秀危峰。其夜家鬼。其兄勇色因为居，乞食，国人有与蒜啖地一亩，乃求蚕种于弟，弟蒸而与之，色不知也。至蚕时，有一蚕生焉，日长寸余，居旬大如牛，食数树叶不足。其弟知之，伺间杀其蚕。经日，四方百里内蚕飞集其家。国人谓之巨蚕，意其蚕之王也。四邻共织之，不供。数唯一茎桔焉，其根长尺余。旁色窃守之，忽为鸟所衔去。旁色逐之上，山五六里，鸟入一石罅，目没径黑，旁色困上石侧。至夜半，月明，见群小儿赤衣共戏。……小儿云：“尔要何物？”一曰：“要酒。”小儿露一金锥子，击石，酒及樵果具。二曰：“要食。”又击之，饼饵羹炙罗于石上。良久，饮食而散，旁色潜摘于石隙。旁色大喜，取其锥而还。所试皆甚市力，因是富雄国力。常以珠佩媚其弟，弟方始悔共前所欺蚕事，仍谓旁色：“试以委般欺我，我或如兄得金锥也”旁色知其愚，谕之不及，乃对其言。弟蒸之，止得一蚕如常蚕，种于之又无绪焉。将减，亦为鸟所衔去。其弟大沙，随之入山。至鸟入处，遂群免，悉尸：‘是汝予金锥者。’乃执之，谒曰：‘尔欲为我锥，〈一作锤〉三跳乎？欲亦举长一丈乎？’其弟请锥长。三日仅困，不成，求衣下走，乃挟共举，鼻如象而归。国人怪而聚观之，渐去而卒。其后子孙以其巨维求怪，因富饶，传戚所在。”

This story may be summarized as follows: a nobleman's younger brother obtains a reward through kindness shown to a silkworm spirit. He gives the silkworm seeds to his elder brother, who steams them. At the proper season, a giant silkworm appears and grows rapidly. The elder brother secretly kills it. Silkworms from across the region gather at the younger

brother's house. A bird carries away a mulberry branch, and the elder brother follows it into the mountains, where he encounters supernatural children who possess a golden awl. He steals the awl and becomes wealthy through its magical powers. Later, the younger brother attempts to imitate him but fails, ultimately suffering humiliation and death. According to Ding Naitong's classification system, this story can roughly be categorized as Type 613A.

In Ding Naitong's classification system, the vast majority of stories may be generalized into one or several plot points that correspond consistently with the overall narrative structure. Most narrative texts emphasize plot, while descriptions primarily serve the special function of a particular object, such as the section "driving away ghosts."

“皮道逢，义熙中，乘车山行。忽有一人，乌衣，径上车言寄载。头上有光，口目皆赤，面被毛。行十里方去，临别语道曰：‘我是驱除大将军，感尔相容。’因留赠银环一双。”

This passage is comparatively easy to identify and classify. Therefore, after synthesizing Ding Naitong's classification methods and Propp's functional categories, the following approach was adopted for the classification of narrative texts:

1. Select suitable narrative texts.
2. For the narrative texts, remove descriptive discourse and highly summarize the content into concise plot chains.
3. Classify according to the most important plot progression, ensuring that each narrative text can only belong to a single category, thereby preserving distinction between categories and high internal consistency within each category. The classification criteria are based on key plot types. For example, if a narrative text can be summarized as "Person A encounters Object A and later transforms into Object/Person B," then this narrative should be

categorized under the category “Transformation,” because “transformation” constitutes the most important plot type.

4. If a text contains two or more plot points, classification is determined according to the relative importance of those plot points, assigning the text to the category containing the most significant plot type.

Based on this method of selection and classification, the 95 narrative texts within the Five *Nuogao* Chapters can be divided into twelve categories.

Category	Core Plot	Number of Passages
Transformation	Centered on “change” as the core, emphasizing transformations between humans and supernatural beings.	23
Encounter	Centered on “humans directly encountering supernatural beings,” emphasizing the process of “encounter” itself.	18
Dream	Centered on “dreams” as the core, often interacting with other functions.	7
Underworld	Centered on “interaction between yin and yang” as the core, manifesting communication between two different systems.	6
Premonition	Centered on “foreknowledge and response,” often expressing delayed verification.	9
Causality	Centered on “the consequences of actions,” with clear causal connections between plot points.	4
Taboo	Centered on “violating rules,” often involving prohibited acts and consequences.	3

Strange Realm	Centered on “entering another spatial domain,” where the space itself is connected with the strange.	5
Encounter with Spirits	Centered on “direct encounters with ghosts and spirits,” often describing interactions with them.	4
Object Monster	Centered on “objects becoming spirits,” possessing narrative cores of transformation and encounter.	7
Illness	Centered on “strange illnesses or diseases,” with plot developments focused on curing or healing.	4
Technique and Magic	Centered on “strange arts and techniques,” often involving individuals with supernatural abilities.	5

From the distribution of categories, it can be seen that “Transformation” and “Encounter” occupy the most prominent positions, followed by “Dream” and “Premonition,” while “Object Monster” and “Underworld” also account for considerable proportions. The development and completion of these categories closely connect with the real world and everyday life, a point that will be discussed further below.

4. Characteristics of Narrative Texts

4.1 Narrative Characteristics of the Texts

4.1.1 The Binary Opposition between “the Strange” and “the Ordinary”

Luo Gang points out in *An Introduction to Narratology* that the binary oppositions discussed by Structuralists function not only in clearly visible categories such as male/female or day/night, but also in areas where binary oppositions are difficult to perceive or have

traditionally been considered nonexistent. He explains the Structuralist viewpoint as follows: “For example, we often define a thing according to the absence of a certain quality. Darkness exists because of the absence of light; iron is cold because of the absence of heat; an object is still because of the absence of movement.” Structuralists believe that such structures form the basis of human communication, as well as the foundation of language and human existence itself. Binary opposition is therefore not merely a narratological structure, but also a fundamental unit in the development of social culture.

In fact, if one steps outside the framework of narratology and instead chooses a more overtly conflictual binary structure, this idea may become easier to understand. In *The Second Sex*, Simone de Beauvoir argues that the development of civilization depends upon the differentiation of the Other. Human beings do not come to know themselves through recognition of the self; rather, they define themselves by establishing the concept of the Other. Through such an exclusionary and heterogeneous structure, human beings come to understand themselves. Put more simply, this means that a cultural subject first categorizes a certain part of existence as its opposite, and then, through reflection upon this opposite, comes to recognize itself. This is precisely the important role played by binary opposition in the self-recognition of culture.

However, just as people fear things that closely resemble humans while not actually being human, human beings also fear phenomena that occur within everyday life yet fail to proceed according to familiar patterns of development. Such phenomena, which differ radically from ordinary life or fail to conform to patterns accumulated through long historical and cultural experience, may be termed “the strange” (*yi*). “异, 怪也。” “异, 奇也。” Among the six definitions provided in the seventh edition of the *Modern Chinese Dictionary*, apart

from its use as a surname, the remaining meanings all fundamentally convey distinction, separation, or difference. Thus, “the strange” refers to circumstances that differ from ordinary reality. Within the context discussed above, the object referred to by “the strange” is precisely the “Other.”

If “the strange” is established as the “Other,” then what constitutes the “self” through which it is observed? In the *Kangxi Dictionary*, the character *chang* (“ordinary” or “constant”) is explained as “《玉篇》恒也。《正韵》久也。” Xunzi states in “Discourse on Heaven”: “The operation of Heaven has its constancy; it does not survive because of Yao, nor perish because of Jie.” From these ancient descriptions of *chang*, it is evident that its central meanings are permanence, stability, and continuity. These meanings stand in direct opposition to “the strange,” and the two concepts describe opposing poles. It may therefore be said that the binary opposite of “the strange” is “the ordinary” or “the constant.”

Based on this binary structure of strange/ordinary, one may observe that fear of the strange is often fundamentally a fear of heterogeneous cultures that fail to conform to the dominant cultural order. There are various methods by which this fear may be resolved. For a cultural subject, one of the simplest and most widespread methods is to reinterpret heterogeneous and othered cultures according to the expectations of the dominant culture itself. Wu Hui proposes the concept of “guiding the strange into the ordinary” (*dao yi wei chang*). She argues that writers of *zhiguai* fiction frequently sought to balance the opposition between strange and ordinary by transforming unstable “strangeness” into something acceptable within the stable world of “the ordinary.” The method most commonly employed was to explain strange phenomena through ethical norms, political morality, and social

principles comprehensible within real society, thereby legitimizing the strange and reintegrating it into the sphere of social order.

Wu Hui further explains the significance of this tradition of *zhiguai* narration from the perspective of historiography:

“As *zhiguai* narration gradually developed into a literary genre, it passed through a stage of coexistence with official historical writing. The strange/ordinary binary structure, as both a narrative mode and a mode of thought, was frequently employed in historical works. The simultaneous appearance of the strange and the ordinary was often used to explain sudden or accidental historical events, such as natural disasters or abrupt political changes. Historiography was adept at establishing connections between such events and the common perceptions of contemporaries.”

Such historiographical ideas are fairly common in historical writing, especially in explanations concerning emperors favored by Heaven or supernatural phenomena generated by tyrannical rule. During the Wei and Jin periods, owing to the popularity of theories such as Yin-Yang and Five Phases cosmology, correlative cosmology between Heaven and humanity, and apocryphal prophecy theology, many political and social events were likewise interpreted through such methods of rendering the abnormal comprehensible.

When Ouyang Xiu later supervised the revision of Tang histories, he vigorously promoted the principle of truthful historical recording and opposed idealist doctrines such as the unity of Heaven and humanity and prophetic theology. From this, it may be inferred that Tang historiographical thought had in fact been influenced, to a certain extent, by traditions of supernatural narration. Yan Zhijie’s examination of the historical sources of the *Old Book of Tang* demonstrates that the officially verifiable historical records of the Tang dynasty

largely ended with Emperor Daizong. After the reign of Emperor Xuanzong, due to social instability, many historical materials had already been lost. Consequently, later historians were forced to supplement their materials with family histories and even unofficial anecdotal histories. Jia Wei's sixty-five-volume annalistic history, *Tangnian Buyilu*, also served as an important source for Later Jin historical compilations. Yet Jia Wei's work was based largely upon hearsay and popular tales current at the time, making it difficult to guarantee the complete reliability of its sources or their freedom from supernatural influence. This demonstrates that even as late as the Later Jin period, Tang historical writing still retained traditions of explaining real-world phenomena through supernatural occurrences.

This phenomenon likewise influenced literary creation during the Tang dynasty. In *Youyang Zazu*, there are indeed passages that connect real-world politics with supernatural narration. One example appears in the chapter "Zhongzhi," which subtly depicts the legitimacy of Taizong's regime:

“高宗初扶床，将戏弄笔。左右试置纸于前，乃乱画满纸。角边画处成草书“敕”字，太宗遽令焚之，不许传外。”

In this passage, a child who has never learned to write is somehow able to casually produce the cursive character “敕” on paper. This is clearly an abnormal phenomenon. In relation to historical reality, Taizong had not yet launched the Taiyuan uprising, and Gaozong was still living under the previous unified empire—the Sui dynasty. Consequently, the description of this event becomes highly suggestive. Does Gaozong's action imply that Heaven was transferring political legitimacy from the Yang family to the Li family? Duan Chengshi himself provides no explicit answer. Yet given Taizong's decision that the matter

should “不许传外,” there is reason to believe that Taizong’s attitude toward the event remained deliberately ambiguous.

However, this tradition becomes significantly weakened within the Five *Nuogao* Chapters. In these narrative texts, descriptions of strange phenomena are often accompanied by phrases such as “不知何怪也” and “不知何之.” The narratives make no attempt to provide explanations consistent with ordinary reality, and in some cases deliberately preserve narrative gaps, as in the following passage:

“大历中, 有士人庄在渭南, 遇疾卒于京, 妻柳氏因庄居。一子年十一二, 夏夜, 其子忽恐悸不眠。三更后, 忽见一老人, 白衣, 两牙出吻外, 熟视之。良久, 渐近床前。床前有婢眠熟, 因扼其喉, 咬然有声, 衣随手碎, 攫食之。须臾骨露, 乃举起饮其五藏。见老人口大如簸箕, 子方叫, 一无所见, 婢已骨矣。数月后, 亦无他。士人祥斋, 日暮, 柳氏露坐逐凉, 有胡蜂绕其首面, 柳氏以扇击堕地, 乃胡桃也。柳氏遽取玩之掌中, 遂长。初如拳, 如碗, 惊顾之际, 已如盘矣。曝然分为两扇, 空中轮转, 声如分蜂。忽合于柳氏首, 柳氏碎首, 齿着于树。其物因飞去, 竟不知何怪也。”

Within this narrative, readers never learn what kind of creature the monster actually is, nor why it behaves in this manner. Although the passage contains a sequence of connected events, the causal relationship between these events remains weak. The author also appears deliberately to obscure causality within the narrative. This suggests that Duan Chengshi did not adopt the previously common strategy of alleviating fear of “the strange” by interpreting heterogeneous cultural phenomena according to the traditions of the dominant culture. Instead, he intentionally blurred the boundary between the strange and the ordinary, creating a narrative tendency in which the strange itself becomes ordinary. This phenomenon will be further explored in the subsequent discussion of narrators.

4.1.2 Gaps Between Events

When discussing the central concerns of narratology, in addition to the tradition of binary opposition, another important issue arises: the relationship between diachrony and synchrony. In other words, narration also involves a discussion of time, and this exploration of time is primarily reflected in the comparison between textual time and story time. Tong Qingbing defines these two forms of time as follows: the act of telling a story—that is, the process of narration—is referred to as textual time, whereas the developmental process of the story content itself, namely the natural temporal progression of events within the story, is referred to as story time. For example, within a text, readers may discover that an author uses two passages of equal length to describe, respectively, a protagonist's activities over the course of an entire morning and the protagonist's fleeting thoughts upon seeing a particular object. From the perspective of reading, the time spent understanding the protagonist's morning activities and the time spent understanding the protagonist's momentary psychological reflections are equal; this is textual time. Story time, however, differs significantly: an entire morning and a fleeting instant are obviously not equivalent durations. In other words, substantial discrepancies may exist between story time and textual time.

What, then, is the relationship between narrative gaps and these two forms of time? Hang Xinyi points out that some scholars define narrative gaps as narrative phenomena in which story time is greater than zero while textual length (that is, textual time) equals zero. Beyond this, when authors intentionally omit certain events, thereby forcing readers to rely upon their own imagination to complete the story, this too constitutes an important form of narrative gap. Thus, two kinds of gaps exist here. The first is a temporal gap caused by the extreme imbalance between textual time and story time; the second is an environmental or

contextual gap produced through deliberate concealment by the author, compelling readers to supplement the narrative through their own life experiences and reading knowledge.

Using four examples—*Nuogao Ji: The Kingdom of Long-Bearded Men*, *Nuogao Ji: A Scholar's Estate in Weinan*, *Nuogao Ji: Chen Pu*, and *Nuogao Ji: Dongping Without Warfare*—Hang Xinyi discusses the categories and causes of narrative gaps in *Youyang Zazu*. Her primary concern lies with gaps relating to character identity, setting, and plot development. During this discussion, one detail deserves particular attention:

“...‘有士人庄在渭南’ omits the identity of the old man in white clothing. The hornet that suddenly appears one year after the scholar’s death is struck to the ground and transforms into a walnut, yet the relationship among these three elements is never explained. Nevertheless, readers may vaguely sense that the suddenly vanished old man in white who devoured humans is likely connected to the hornet that later appears and kills the scholar’s wife.”

What is emphasized here is the discontinuity between plot segments and the incompleteness of narration. That is, the author does not explain the relationships among these events, but merely presents readers with several isolated episodes, relying upon readers’ lived experience and imaginative participation to complete the story. This phenomenon is extremely common within the Five *Nuogao* Chapters, particularly in shorter narrative texts. The following two stories illustrate this feature:

“和州刘录事者，大历中，罢官居和州旁县。食兼数人，尤能食鲙，常言鲙味未尝果腹。邑客乃网鱼百余斤，会于野亭，观其下箸。初食鲙数叠，忽似哽，咯出一骨珠子，大如黑豆，乃置于茶瓯中，以叠覆之。食未半，怪覆瓯倾侧，刘举视之，向者骨珠已长数寸，如人状。座客竞观之，随视而长。顷刻长及人，遂鲙刘，因欧流血。良久，各散走。一循厅之西，一转厅之左，

俱及后门相触，翕成一人，乃刘也，神已痴矣。半日方能言，访其所以，皆不省。自是恶鲙。

冯坦者，常有疾，医令浸蛇酒服之。初服一瓮子，疾减半。又令家人园中执一蛇，投瓮中，封闭七日。及开，蛇跃出，举首尺余，出门，因失所在。其过迹，地坟起数寸。陆绍郎中又言，尝记一人浸蛇酒，前后杀蛇数十头。一日，自临瓮窥酒，有物跳出啗其鼻将落，视之，乃蛇头骨。因疮毁其鼻如劓焉。”

Narrative gaps likewise appear within these two texts. In the story “The Recording Clerk Liu of Hezhou,” why Liu spits out the bone pearl, and why he is able to return to his original state after splitting apart, are events that remain isolated from one another in terms of causal explanation. The author never explicitly states why these occurrences happen. Yet through the arrangement of the text and the reader’s interpretive experience, readers may infer that Liu’s misfortune is probably connected to his excessive consumption of raw fish. The gaps found in “Feng Tan” belong to the same category. The two stories recorded within “Feng Tan” possess no direct causal relationship whatsoever. At most, they share the same descriptive object—snakes. Yet through the careful arrangement of narrative structure, readers are led to suspect that the phenomenon experienced by Feng Tan is related to the revenge-seeking snake described later, thereby producing a subtle anxiety: will the snake return to take revenge upon Feng Tan?

Many similar examples of narrative gaps exist. Duan Chengshi’s arrangement of these gaps is simultaneously intentional and unintentional. First, because of the structural limitations inherent in *biji* fiction, the narration of space and time presents considerable difficulties. Second, Duan Chengshi’s own literary inclination toward “seeking the marvelous” (*souqi*) influenced the pervasive presence of narrative gaps throughout *Youyang Zazu*. Finally, the deliberate refusal to explain background details and the intentional blurring

of narrative logic contribute atmospherically to the mysterious quality of the stories. Within these narratives, strange tales exist simultaneously “here” and “there.” Supernatural events should, theoretically, belong to a transcendent realm beyond reality, yet Duan Chengshi intentionally obscures the distance between ordinary and supernatural spaces, as in the following passage:

“开成末，永兴坊百姓王乙掘井，过常井一丈余无水。忽听向下有人语及鸡声，甚喧闹，近如隔壁。井匠惧，不敢掘。街司申金吾韦处仁将军，韦以事涉怪异，不复奏，遽令塞之。据亡新求《周秦故事》：谒者阁上得骊山本，李斯领徒七十二万人作陵，凿之以韦程，三十七岁，固地中水泉，奏曰“已深已极，凿之不入，烧之不可燃，叩之空空，如下天状。”抑知厚地之下，别有天地也。”

In this description, the subterranean world—that is, humanity’s imagined realm of the underworld—is separated from the material world inhabited by living humans by only a thin layer of earth, as though digging just slightly deeper would lead directly into the realm of the dead. The real world and the supernatural world merge ingeniously together while still maintaining a subtle separation. Existing outside reality yet immediately adjacent to it, this mode of depiction produces a powerful sense of realism for readers. The supernatural realm appears to inhabit a hidden corner of ordinary space, always prepared to draw those of the real world into its domain.

4.1.3 The Reliable Narrator

In the depiction of horror stories, authors often strengthen the sense of terror experienced by readers by enhancing the story’s connection to reality. For example, a story may unfold in the first person, with the narrator emphasizing at the beginning that the events were personally experienced during the period of being “sent down to the countryside.”

However, for readers, because of the inherent unreliability of the narrator itself (for instance, the author may never actually have experienced the “sent-down youth” movement), even with such narrative construction, the atmosphere of horror may still remain insufficient.

Yet the issue of narration extends even further. When elements beyond the protagonist in a story clearly possess fictional qualities, horror narratives function merely as a mode of generating a reading experience. But when narration is based upon the narrator’s own life experiences, readers often find it difficult to distinguish between the real narrator and the implied narrator. This problem can be observed in the opening of Lu Xun’s “At the Wineshop”:

“我从北地向东南旅行，绕道访了我的家乡，就到S城。这城离我的故乡不过三十里，坐了小船，小半天可到，我曾在这里的学校里当过一年的教员。”

Here, due to the characteristics of first-person narration, combined with readers’ familiarity with Lu Xun, some readers who are less sensitive to narrative identity often mistakenly equate the “I” within the text with Lu Xun himself. In reality, however, the story is almost entirely fictional. Readers know neither who the “I” conversing with Lü Weifu actually is, nor who Lü Weifu himself is, nor even where the story truly takes place. Thus, the apparent narrator “I” is clearly unreliable, and the relationship between this narrator and Lu Xun—the actual narrator—remains uncertain.

Debates concerning the true identity of the narrator “I” have consequently developed in two directions. Those who believe the relationship between “I” and Lu Xun is unified argue that the text is authentic and reliable, and that Lü Weifu is in fact a representation of Fan Ainong, making the story essentially a record of a conversation between the two. Conversely, those who regard the narrator as unreliable propose that Lü Weifu may simply be

a projection of the protagonist himself, with Lu Xun using the form of self-dialogue to express his own thoughts; in this interpretation, the protagonist and Lu Xun are not equivalent. Thus, discussions surrounding the “I” demonstrate that the narrator’s identity and reliability profoundly influence both the interpretation of the text and the understanding of the culture represented behind it.

Earlier, this discussion considered how horror fiction enhances realism through narrative perspective. Yet such techniques are fundamentally employed because the author, as the true narrator, already knows the story itself to be fictional. In the case of *Youyang Zazu*, however, matters are far more complicated. The first issue that must be clarified in relation to *Youyang Zazu* is the identity of its actual narrator. Although most texts exhibit the characteristics of *leishu* compilations, in which the narrator’s presence is relatively weak, introductions to characters and evaluative remarks appended to certain stories make it possible to determine that the true narrator of *Youyang Zazu* is Duan Chengshi himself. For example:

“庐州舒城县蚰，成式三从房伯父，太和三年庐州某官，庭前忽有蚰出，大如食指，长三尺，白项下有两足。足正如雀脚，步于垣下。经数日方死。”

Here, through the introduction of the protagonist’s identity, the text reveals its actual narrator—Duan Chengshi—because the story is narrated through Duan’s recounting of an incident involving his own uncle.

Once the narrator has been identified, a review of the text reveals something striking: when introducing the protagonists of narrative texts, the author frequently strengthens their credibility by explaining their relationship to himself. Through descriptions of his interactions with these individuals, Duan Chengshi encourages readers to believe in the authenticity of the

events described. Furthermore, in texts where no relationship between protagonist and author is specified, there are often precise references to locations or times, using coordinates rooted in real life to indicate that the events truly occurred.

This feature becomes even more apparent in chapters with weaker narrative qualities, such as “Guang Dongzhi” and “Zhongzhi.” Some passages can even be matched with similar records in official histories. One example is the account in “Zhongzhi” concerning Emperor Taizong and the white magpie:

“贞观中，忽有白鹊构巢于寝殿前槐树上。其巢合欢如腰鼓，左右拜舞称贺。上曰：“我尝笑隋炀帝好祥瑞。瑞在得贤，此何足贺？”乃命毁其巢，鹊放于野外。”

In the *Old Book of Tang*, a similarly skeptical attitude toward auspicious omens is recorded as follows:

“上谓侍臣曰：“神仙事本虚妄，空有其名。秦始皇非分爱好，遂为方士所诈，乃遣童男女数千人随徐福入海求仙药，方士避秦苛虐，因留不归。始皇犹海侧踟蹰以待之，还至沙丘而死。汉武帝为求仙，乃将女嫁道术人，事既无验，便行诛戮。据此二事，神仙不烦妄求也。””

It can be seen that Duan Chengshi’s language is far closer to everyday life, while the stories themselves possess corresponding historical evidence. In this respect, *Youyang Zazu* greatly enhances the authenticity of its narratives. Such narrative characteristics not only reflect Duan Chengshi’s personal aesthetic preferences, but also reveal his historiographical outlook. Through interpretation of these texts, one may glimpse the cultural mentality of Tang society. These narrative characteristics are likewise reflected in comparisons both within *Youyang Zazu* itself and between *Youyang Zazu* and external texts.

4.2 Internal Comparison of Narrative Texts within the Same Category

4.2.1 The “Transformation” Category

From the perspective of narrative structure, the core of the “Transformation” category focuses on the changes produced through interactions between humans and anomalous beings or phenomena. These transformations may generally be divided into three types: humans transforming into supernatural beings or ascending to a higher state; supernatural beings revealing their true forms or dissipating; and reciprocal interactions between paintings and humans. Among these, the most numerous category is the second type, namely supernatural beings revealing their original forms or ultimately disappearing.

For these texts, distinctions beyond narrative structure itself reveal a tendency toward binary opposition. In terms of endings, the texts may be classified into either the disappearance of the supernatural being or the death of the protagonist. In terms of the transformations themselves, they may be classified according to whether the transformation is reversible or irreversible. Different classificatory criteria reflect attention to different thematic concerns. Taking *Zhi Nuogao: Black Fish Valley in Five Counties of Guozhou* as an example:

“虢州五城县黑鱼谷，贞元中，百姓王用业炭于谷中。中有水，方数步，常見二黑鱼，长尺余，游于水上。用伐木饥困，遂食一鱼。其弟惊曰：“此鱼或谷中灵物，兄奈何杀此！”有顷，其妻饷之。用运斤不已，久乃转面。妻觉状貌有异，呼其弟视之。忽褫衣号跃，变为虎焉，径入山。时而杀獐鹿，夜掷庭中。如此二年。一日日昏，叩门自名曰：“我用也。”弟应曰：“我兄变为虎三年矣，何鬼假吾兄姓名？”又曰：“我往年杀黑鱼，冥谪为虎。比因杀人，冥官答余一百。今免放，杖伤遍体。汝第视予无疑也。”弟喜，遽开门，见一人，头犹是虎，因怖死。举家叫呼奔避，竟为村人格杀之。验其身有黑子，信王用也，但首未变。元和中，处士赵齐约常至谷中，见村人说。”

In terms of narrative structure, this story belongs to the category of “humans transforming into supernatural beings.” In terms of its ending, it belongs to the category of

“protagonist death.” In terms of transformation itself, it belongs to the category of “irreversible transformation.” These constitute the distinct classifications assigned to the same narrative text under three different classificatory systems.

Simply put, classifications based primarily upon narrative structure focus on the narrator’s categorization of story types. The study of narrative structure helps illuminate similarities between texts and differences in narrative patterns. Attention to endings, meanwhile, concerns the effects stories exert upon people. Endings are often closely connected to the author’s narrative purpose, and readers, through interaction with their own lived experiences, may reinterpret the story retrospectively and generate their own understandings. This forms a process of mutual interaction between reader and author. Consequently, focus upon endings frequently points toward broader cultural psychology within society. Attention to transformation itself, by contrast, explores the relationship between text and culture: whether the binary opposition between the strange and the ordinary is reversible, or at least mutually transformable. Through attempts to answer such questions, readers and authors consciously construct a supernatural world capable of sustaining spiritual meaning.

From the text *Zhi Nuogao: Black Fish Valley in Five Counties of Guozhou*, the attitude and inclination toward supernatural beings are unmistakably clear: people fear and reject the supernatural. Judging from the language employed in the ending, the author clearly wishes to demonstrate that the event genuinely occurred in the real world. In such narratives, the object being described is essentially the author’s projection of reality itself. One may say that precisely because the event is so absurd and unbelievable, yet simultaneously so convincing within the author’s worldview, the author repeatedly emphasizes that the account

is recorded truthfully, thereby presenting a society in which reality and supernatural forces coexist.

The story *Nuogao Ji: The Jealous Wife Ford* reflects disasters produced by extreme emotional tendencies:

“妒妇津，相传言，晋太始中，刘伯玉妻段氏，字光明，性妒忌。伯玉常于妻前诵《洛神赋》，语其妻曰：“娶妇得如此，吾无憾焉。”明光曰：“君何以水神善而欲轻我？吾死，何愁不为水神。”其夜乃自沉而死。死后七日，托梦语伯玉曰：“君本愿神，吾今得为神也。”伯玉寤而觉之，遂终身不复渡水。有妇人渡此津者，皆坏衣枉妆，然后敢济，不尔风波暴发。丑妇虽妆饰而渡，其神亦不妒也。妇人渡河无风浪者，以为己丑，不致水神怒。丑妇讳之，无不皆自毁形容，以塞嗤笑也。故齐人语曰：“欲求好妇，立在津口。妇立水旁，好丑自彰。””

In this story, the wife Duan's intense jealousy directly causes the transformation and resulting tragedy. In terms of classification, this narrative differs little from the previous example; however, here one can clearly perceive a stronger didactic intention on the author's part. The wife throws herself into the river because of her overwhelming emotional obsession. Even after ascending into a water deity, her essential nature remains unchanged. Indeed, it is precisely because she is inherently jealous that, even as a water spirit, she continues to harm others out of envy for physical beauty, to the extent that women crossing the ford must deliberately make themselves appear ugly in order to pass safely. This is obviously behavior that the author does not approve of. The concluding saying among the people of Qi further demonstrates that the wife's actions merely make her an object of ridicule and are not worthy of admiration. In other words, descriptions of transformation not only reflect the world as perceived by the author, but also reveal the author's didactic purpose.

4.2.2 The “Encounter” Category

The “Encounter” category constitutes the second largest classification and serves as the secondary thematic focus within the Five Chapters of *Nuogao*. Narrative texts within this category generally follow a similar narrative structure, which may broadly be summarized as: “chance encounter with a supernatural being → interaction/conflict → departure or revelation of the supernatural being.” Compared with the “Transformation” category, the “Encounter” category pays greater attention to the interactive relationship between humans and supernatural entities.

Overall, these texts may be divided into two subcategories: antagonistic relationships and coexistence relationships. In most texts, supernatural beings and humans are ultimately incompatible with one another. Even in the relatively less confrontational stories, the conclusion often ends with the disappearance or expulsion of the supernatural being. One example is *Nuogao Ji: Duke Guo Dai*:

“郭代公尝山居，中夜有人面如盘，瞋目出于灯下。公了无惧色，徐染翰题其颊曰：“久戍人偏老，长征马不肥。”公之警句也。题毕吟之，其物遂灭。数日，公随樵闲步，见巨木上有白耳，大如数斗，所题句在焉。”

The text *Duke Guo Dai* deserves particular attention. On the one hand, it depicts the eventual disappearance of the supernatural entity, yet the relationship between the being and the human protagonist, while incompatible, is not overtly antagonistic. On the other hand, contextual clues provide readers with reason to suspect that the “supernatural being” encountered by Duke Guo Dai was actually a misperception caused by poor nighttime lighting, with the so-called apparition in fact being a type of fungus growing upon a large tree.

Such descriptions also appear elsewhere among the selected narrative texts. For example:

“秀才田暉云：太和六年秋，凉州西县百姓妻产一子，四手四足，一身分两面，项上发一穗，长至足。时朝伯峻为县令。”

From the perspective of modern medicine, readers may recognize this description as a case of conjoined twins. Yet for people of the time, whose medical knowledge was limited, such phenomena proved difficult to explain and therefore had to be interpreted through metaphysical or supernatural frameworks. Consequently, one may observe that certain texts within the “Encounter” category are essentially distortions of real life. This corresponds to the broader relationship between literature and reality: literature simultaneously reflects reality and distorts it.

Another group of texts within the “Encounter” category more prominently reflects antagonistic relationships between humans and supernatural beings. One representative example is *Nuogao Ji: Wang Shen, a Commoner West of Wangyuan Relay Station*:

“贞元中，望苑驿西有百姓王申，手植榆于路傍成林，构茅屋数椽，夏月常馈浆水于行人，官者即延憩具茗。有儿年十三，每令伺客。忽一日，白其父：“路有女子求水。”因令呼入。女少年，衣碧襦，白幅巾，自言：“家在此南十余里，夫死无儿，今服褫矣，将适马嵬访亲情，丐衣食。”言语明悟，举止可爱。王申乃留饭之，谓曰：“今日暮夜可宿此，达明去也。”女亦欣然从之。其妻遂纳之后堂，呼之为妹。倩其成衣数事，自午至戌悉办。针缀细密，殆非人工。王申大惊异，妻犹爱之，乃戏曰：“妹既无极亲，能为我家作新妇子乎？”女笑曰：“身既无托，愿执粗井灶。”王申即日赁衣贯礼为新妇。其夕暑热，戒其夫：“近多盗，不可辟门。”即举巨椽捍而寝。及夜半，王申妻梦其子披发诉曰：“被食将尽矣。”惊欲省其子。王申怒之：“老人得好新妇，喜极呖言耶！”妻还睡，复梦如初。申与妻秉烛呼其子及新妇，悉不复应。

启其户，户牢如鍵，乃坏门。闩才开，有物圆目凿齿，体如蓝色，冲人而去。其子唯余脑骨及发而已。”

Wang Shen, a Commoner West of Wangyuan Relay Station preserves a rather obvious narrative gap. Although the phrase “针缀细密，殆非人工” subtly hints that the newly arrived bride may not be human, readers are unable to confirm this suspicion until the conclusion of the narrative. Furthermore, the text never explains why the supernatural bride wishes to devour humans. Such abrupt jumps and omissions in plot development exemplify the phenomenon of narrative gaps.

Here, the supernatural entity briefly comes into contact with human society, while humans, unable to explain unusual phenomena in reality, transform them into supernatural beings through imagination. In this way, the supernatural world projects itself into ordinary life.

4.3 External Comparison of Narrative Texts within the Same Category

4.3.1 The “Dream” Category

For texts belonging to the “Dream” category, an important distinction must first be made. Within *Youyang Zazu*, there exists an independent chapter entitled *Dreams (Meng)*, which records material related to dream omens, nightmares, and dream interpretation. According to Guo Qianqian’s study of the *Dreams* chapter, the most prevalent type within the chapter consists of fulfilled dream omens, a pattern similar to the dominant “Dream” narrative mode found within the Five Chapters of *Nuogao*. Li Kuolong further points out that the dream-related stories emphasized in *Youyang Zazu*’s *Dreams* chapter primarily focus upon dream content, the outcomes produced by dreams, and the social group of dream interpreters. Compared with dream narratives in Tang chuanqi tales, *Youyang Zazu: Dreams*

is evidently more concerned with the mysterious powers associated with dreams. Ge Yingying, meanwhile, has discussed the profound dream-divination culture of the Tang dynasty reflected behind the *Dreams* chapter.

Although the dream narratives within the Five Chapters of *Nuogao* differ slightly in detail from those found in the *Dreams* chapter, they generally follow similar formal patterns. Among the selected narrative texts, one particularly striking feature is that the outcomes produced by these dreams are overwhelmingly negative; only the passage concerning *Li Zhengji* concludes with the favorable ending of ennoblement and appointment to high office.

In terms of narrative structure, the selected texts primarily follow the sequence: “entering a dream → events within the dream → awakening and verification.” Narratively speaking, these texts place greater emphasis upon interactions between human beings and dream-events. When discussing dream narratives in Tang chuanqi literature, Li Kuolong notes that such stories closely connected dream experiences with the writers’ own lived realities. This creative tendency significantly enhanced the realism of Tang chuanqi. By contrast, the stories in *Youyang Zazu* are more inclined toward recording strange events and unusual individuals, resulting in a stronger sense of mystery.

Within the narrative texts of *Youyang Zazu*, dreams function more as a means of interpreting reality, though this interpretive mechanism is closely aligned with metaphysical thought. In Tang chuanqi literature, however, the boundary between dreams and reality becomes considerably more blurred. As zhiguai notebooks emerged during the formative stages of Chinese fiction, occupying a transitional position between traditional historiographical writing and later fictional forms, they also reflect the broader development

of classical Chinese fiction from a historiographical emphasis upon factual recording toward a literary emphasis upon readerly experience.

4.3.2 The “Omen” Category

Texts belonging to the “Omen” category describe the process through which omens are fulfilled. The difference between this category and the “Dream” category lies in the fact that omens mentioned in dream narratives possess a delayed realization, while the story time itself is extremely brief. Often, the protagonist awakens from the dream world only for the dream’s contents to be immediately fulfilled. By contrast, “Omen” narratives generally involve a much longer story time, and the omens themselves are usually grounded in reality. They are discovered within ordinary life rather than known solely to the individual concerned. Consider the following two texts:

“太和五年，复州医人王超，善用针，病无不差。于午忽无病死，经宿而苏。言始梦至一处，城壁台殿如王者居。见一人卧，召前袒视，左髀有肿，大如杯。令超治之，即为针出脓升余。顾黄衣吏曰：“可领毕也。”超随入一门，门署曰毕院，庭中有人眼数千聚成山，视肉迭瞬明灭。黄衣曰：“此即毕也。”俄有二人，形甚奇伟，分处左右，鼓巨箠吹激，眼聚扇而起，或飞或走，或为人者，顷刻而尽。超访其故，黄衣吏曰：“有生之类，先死而毕。”言次，忽活。”

“成都乞儿严七师，幽陋凡贱，涂垢臭秽不可近。言语无度，往往应于未兆。居西市悲田坊，常有帖衙俳儿干满川、白迦、叶玢、张美、张翱等五人为火。七师遇于途，各与十五文，勤勤若相别为赠之意。后数日，监军院宴满川等为戏，以求衣粮。少师李相怒，各杖十五，递出界。凡四五年间，人争施与。每得钱帛，悉用修观。语人曰：“寺何足修。”方知折寺之兆也。今失所在。”

The text *The Physician Wang Chao of Fuzhou* belongs to the “Dream” category. From the account of Wang Chao journeying through a supernatural realm in his dream before returning to life, it is not difficult to see that within this narrative process there is effectively no story time separating Wang Chao’s dream from his resurrection. The moment he awakens from the dream, he revives immediately.

By contrast, the various events narrated in *Yan Qishi, the Beggar of Chengdu* are separated by clear temporal intervals, and the story time is therefore discontinuous. In other words, within *Youyang Zazu*, dreams function as an extension of real life: human experiences and actions continue into the dream realm. Omens, however, function as metaphysical signs or warnings within the text. The two are therefore fundamentally distinct in nature.

5. Cultural-Historical Analysis of Narrative Texts

5.1 The Transformation of Prominent Narrative Features and Their Cultural Implications

In ancient Chinese *biji* fiction, narratives concerning “journeys to immortals” were extremely common. Descriptions of immortal realms and the methods by which one entered them constantly changed alongside historical developments and shifts in social belief systems. Lai Chuntao analyzed and summarized the immortal-travel stories in *Youyang Zazu*, arguing that the most representative feature of these stories is the secularization of immortal realms. This characteristic is particularly evident in both temporal and spatial dimensions.

First, in terms of space, before the Tang dynasty immortal realms were separated from the human world. They existed on a lofty plane beyond ordinary reach. Although some secularizing modifications had already appeared during the Han dynasty, immortal realms were still generally inaccessible places. This situation underwent a dramatic transformation

during the Tang period. In the narrative texts of *Youyang Zazu*, immortal realms were no longer extremely distant places. Although they still maintained a certain distance from everyday human life, the journey to such realms was no longer unattainable. In some cases, entering immortal realms or other supernatural spaces inhabited by nonhuman beings became remarkably easy. For example, in the narrative of “Changxu Kingdom,” the protagonist does not undergo trials or cross insurmountable geographical barriers to reach the supernatural realm. Instead, he simply arrives there because “风吹到一处.” Later, when the protagonist is entrusted by the king to seek help from the Dragon King, the description reads: “世人登舟，瞬息而至。” Within the text, story time is almost negligible. Compared with earlier traditions, in which one might leave an immortal realm only to discover that countless years had passed and all family and friends had long died, the temporal distance here is drastically shortened.

In Duan Chengshi’s writing, time—especially story time—is significantly compressed. Time in the immortal realm and time in the mortal world are nearly synchronized. This represents a clear tendency toward secularization. Once the temporal gulf separating immortals from ordinary humans is subtly erased, the mystery surrounding immortals and immortal realms is inevitably weakened, allowing the supernatural world to become more closely integrated with reality.

Second, spatially speaking, the distance between immortal realms—or supernatural spaces more generally—and the human world is also dramatically reduced in Duan Chengshi’s writing. Beyond the previously discussed passage from “Wang Yi Digs a Well,” in which the underworld seems to lie directly beneath the earth, the “otherworld” narratives also reveal that entering supernatural realms is not only easy, but at times even somewhat

vulgar. For example, in “Chengdu Fangzheng Zhang He,” the protagonist enters the immortal realm through the following method: “坊正引手扞拂乳，揭之，乳坏成穴如碗，即挺身入穴，因拽豪家子臂，不觉同在穴中。道行十数步，忽睹高门崇墉，状如州县。” This means of discovering the entrance to an immortal realm is clearly unlike earlier traditions, which required arduous journeys over mountains or guidance by supernatural beings. Not only is the process integrated into ordinary daily life, but the physical actions involved are even somewhat inelegant. This further demonstrates that, by the late Tang period, the powers associated with immortal realms and religion had already become highly secularized.

Another striking example of this secularizing tendency appears in the depiction of the underworld and immortals themselves. In Duan Chengshi’s writing, the underworld possesses a clear hierarchical order, and its mode of operation resembles the bureaucratic structure of the human official world. Immortals and messengers of the underworld display distinctly human flaws. Zhang Tianweng steals Liu Weng’s position as Heavenly Emperor, yet still worries about Liu Weng’s breakfast and appoints him governor of Mount Tai. Li Hezi, a local bully fond of abusing cats and dogs, is able to bribe ghosts sent to claim his life in exchange for an extension of his lifespan. Although he ultimately fails because time in the underworld and the human world do not correspond—three years in the underworld amounting to only three days in the mortal realm—it is nevertheless clear that the ghostly officials are not emotionless executors of fate. Rather, they are anthropomorphized beings with their own personalities and emotions.

The monsters and spirits depicted in the book also deserve careful attention. In the “magic arts” category, there is the following passage:

“临瀨西北有寺，寺僧智通，常持《法华经》入禅。每晏坐，必求寒林静境，殆非人所至。经数年，忽夜有人环其院呼智通，至晓声方息。历三夜，声侵户，智通不耐，应曰：‘汝呼我何事？可人来言也。’有物长六尺余，皂衣青面，张目巨吻，见僧初亦合手。智通熟视良久，谓曰：‘尔寒乎？就是向火。’物亦就坐，智通但念经。至五更，物为火所醉，因闭目开口，据炉而鼾。智通睹之，乃以香匙举灰火置其口中。物大呼起走，至阊若蹶声。其寺背山，智通及明视蹶处，得木皮一片。登山寻之，数里，见大青桐，树稍已童矣，其下凹根若新缺然。僧以木皮附之，合无踪隙。其半有薪者创成一蹬，深六寸余，盖魅之口，灰火满其中，火犹荧荧。智通以焚之，其怪自绝。”

The spirit in this text not only fails to harm anyone, but is instead severely tricked by the monk. Zhizhong takes advantage of the creature's sleep and places burning embers into its mouth. Compared with the monk Zhizhong, the monster actually appears far more harmless. Similar examples appear elsewhere, such as in “South of Songzi County in Jingnan,” where a gecko spirit invites a scholar to spend the night together out of fear of loneliness. In contrast, the scholar behaves rudely and destroys the spirit's entire nest after dawn. Compared with the scholar, the spirit appears far more affectionate and loyal.

In these narratives, Duan Chengshi's didactic intentions are not particularly explicit. Yet through the contrast between innocent, simple-minded supernatural beings and morally flawed humans, readers may sense that interactions between humans and nonhuman beings are perhaps not so different from interactions among humans themselves.

It can thus be said that these narrative texts depict a highly secularized supernatural world in *Youyang Zazu*. Immortals are not flawless beings of perfect virtue; on the contrary, they may possess moral failings and deeply human weaknesses. Likewise, monsters are not always terrifying creatures with ferocious appearances—some are even more innocent than humans. On the one hand, such portrayals demonstrate that the cultural concerns of late Tang

society had shifted away from abstract religious transcendence toward concrete human experience and emotion. On the other hand, as collections of folk tales, these stories also reflect the concerns of ordinary people in late Tang society. The afterlife was too distant and uncertain, whereas questions of life and death were immediate realities. In the comparatively turbulent society of the late Tang, these existential concerns became issues every individual was forced to confront.

5.2 Cultural Characteristics Reflected in the Narrative Texts

In the five “Nuogao” chapters, when confronted with supernatural beings and overwhelming forces beyond ordinary human understanding, common people are often powerless to resist them. Duan Chengshi’s writing certainly reveals his particular fascination with strange people and bizarre events, and readers can likewise derive aesthetic pleasure from the marvelous and uncanny world depicted in the text. Yet what cannot be overlooked is the central concern running throughout *Youyang Zazu*: the relationship between humanity and the “other” or the “strange.” Can humans confront the nonhuman and maintain agency in the face of terrifying supernatural forces, or are they ultimately incapable of resisting nature and only able to drift along with its power? Different texts provide different answers to this question. However, at least within the stories of *Youyang Zazu*, readers have reason to believe that through the secularization of the supernatural world, Duan Chengshi attempts to offer the following response: in the face of inevitable death, humanity is not entirely powerless.

Within these narrative texts, there are many stories involving spirits harming humans or interactions between humans and the underworld. Under Duan Chengshi’s pen, both demons and immortals display great diversity; even the underworld itself possesses hierarchies, regulations, and bureaucratic procedures. Such depictions do not seem

fundamentally different from the human world: people likewise possess varied personalities, both good and evil, and real society itself is deeply stratified. Thus, although death is an unavoidable issue that everyone must confront, the world after death appears neither chaotic nor unknowable. Rather, it is something that can be understood and interpreted.

Within the traditional Confucian worldview, valuing life and fearing death are natural human instincts. Although death is an unavoidable law of nature, this does not mean that people can do nothing when facing it. While Duan Chengshi's stories indeed contain numerous narrative gaps, it should also be noted that his depictions of the underworld are often governed by causal logic. Those who commit evil fear punishment in hell, while those who perform good deeds are frequently rewarded. Yu Daoshi, for example, out of a momentary kindness, once gave a spirit creature a ride in his cart and later received recompense from that creature. Such moral and didactic ideas embedded within the texts reveal not only the author's own values but also the broader cultural customs of society.

On the other hand, among these narrative texts, the motif of reincarnation is relatively rare, while the motif of resurrection after death appears much more frequently. These two motifs reflect different cultural concerns. The focus on reincarnation points toward people's inability to escape the suffering of reality, leading them to place their hopes in a future life. By contrast, the emphasis on resurrection suggests that people's attention is directed more toward this life than the next; what truly concerns them is their present existence. This turn toward human-centered concerns also reflects broader transformations in historiographical and literary thought since the Tang dynasty, shifting away from the Six Dynasties tradition in which gods and humans were not clearly distinguished and toward an emphasis on factual recording and lived reality.

The mysterious aura of metaphysical speculation gradually receded. Rather than treating supernatural powers in zhiguai and chuanqi literature as wholly transcendent, people increasingly attempted to incorporate them into everyday life, thereby reducing their cultural otherness through familiarity and acceptance. At the same time, these motifs also correspond to the ideas of Confucianism, Buddhism, and Daoism. Confucianism emphasizes this-worldly reality; Buddhism focuses on the afterlife; and Daoism seeks immortality through cultivation in response to the problem of life and death. Duan Chengshi himself was deeply devoted to Buddhism. In other sections of the text, stories occasionally appear in which Buddhist monks and Daoist priests compete in magical arts, and these tales often end with the monk's victory. Yet in the selected texts, such sectarian tendencies are not especially pronounced. Instead, what stands out more clearly is a tendency toward the integration of the Three Teachings. The underworld and resurrection are obviously Daoist features, while descriptions of the bureaucratic management of the dead often resemble the Buddhist concept of registers of life and death. Finally, the characterization of figures within these stories reflects Confucian moral values. These ideological strands intermingle and ultimately produce narrative texts characterized by the syncretism of Confucianism, Buddhism, and Daoism.

Another consequence of this focus on worldly life is the transformation of attitudes toward wealth and money. One passage in the narrative texts states:

“元和初，洛阳村百姓王清，佣力得钱五银。因买田畔一枯栗树，将为薪以求利。经宿，为邻人盗斫，创及腹，忽有黑蛇举首如臂，人语曰：‘我王清本也，汝勿斫。’其人惊惧，失斤而走。及明，王清率子孙薪之，复掘其根，根下得大瓮二，散钱实之。王清因是获利而归。十余年巨富，遂醵钱成龙形，号王清本。”

Miao Xianjun points out that this passage, to some extent, reflects the life ideals and values of late Tang intellectuals. The story is founded upon fantasy and quite clearly expresses the ordinary Tang person's dream of sudden wealth. Concern with money itself represents anxiety about real life, for enlightened monks and immortal Daoists, after all, have no need for gold or silver in order to survive.

6. Cultural-Historical Characteristics in the Supernatural Transformations of *Youyang Zazu*

During the development of cultural history studies, it was precisely through the influence of literary theory that New Cultural History came to display its own distinctive theoretical character. Lloyd S. Kramer argues that language, texts, and narrative structures all play active roles in the creation and representation of historical facts. Historical writing itself therefore possesses a certain literary nature.

In the course of Chinese historical development, however, an awareness of the distinction between literature and history did not begin to emerge until the Han dynasty. Moreover, the term "literature and history" (*wenshi*) only truly acquired its dual meanings of "literature" and "history" during the Southern Dynasties. It was from this point onward that people gradually recognized the fundamental differences in nature between literature and history, and literature began to diverge from history as an independent field.

The massive historiographical projects undertaken in the early Tang dynasty, although never entirely completed, nevertheless reflected the great importance attached to history. The scale and breadth of these projects were extraordinary within Chinese cultural history. Yet did the separation of history and literature truly become complete in the Tang dynasty? Judging from the compilation process of the *Old Book of Tang*, the answer is probably no. At this

stage, people not only recognized the independence of literature but also consciously pursued literary qualities. As a result, Tang historical writing developed a tendency toward literary stylization, while Tang literary creation, under the strong official emphasis on historiography, could hardly avoid the influence of historical consciousness. Thus, it may be said that the separation of literature and history had only just begun in the Tang dynasty and was still far from complete.

The mutual influence between historiographical and literary ideas not only endowed historical works with literary value but also caused literary works to exhibit significant historiographical tendencies. In zhiguai fiction, this is reflected in the quasi-encyclopedic nature of such works and in the authors' conscious or unconscious creative intentions. Wang Xin points out that the zhiguai characteristic of "searching for marvels and recording the strange" was a narrative method widely employed by the public. Influenced by the historical and cultural contexts of different dynasties, these zhiguai stories essentially represent the expression of authors' lived experiences and knowledge within specific intellectual frameworks. Only by approaching zhiguai fiction from the perspective of cultural history can one truly understand and reconstruct its historical context of creation.

Traditional views of zhiguai fiction often regard such stories as products of subjective imagination lacking any basis in reality. Yet in *Youyang Zazu*, Duan Chengshi repeatedly emphasizes the authenticity and reliability of the narrator. Through references to concrete realities and through texts that can mutually corroborate official historical records, he constructs a strong sense of realism for his stories. On this level, the work can no longer be regarded merely as fictional fantasy literature. From a microhistorical perspective, it may be considered a record of Duan Chengshi's personal history of knowledge; from a

macrohistorical perspective, because its times, places, and figures are often verifiable, the text possesses a certain degree of historical source value. Therefore, zhiguai fiction should not be simplistically classified as purely fictional fantasy literature. Rather, attention must also be paid to the historiographical background and epistemological significance underlying the supernatural transformations described within these stories.

7. Conclusion and Reflection

New Cultural History theory maintains that the study of cultural history cannot be conducted independently of literary theory. René Wellek once wrote that “literature can obviously substitute for many things—for travel or residence abroad; for direct experience and imagined life; and it can also be used by historians as a form of social document.” As a spiritual activity unique to humanity, literature not only reflects reality but also exerts an active influence upon it. Literary activity originates from reality while simultaneously transcending it; it reflects reality even as it reshapes and distorts that reality through the writer’s own thought. Therefore, it can be said that every literary activity reflects reality to a certain degree, as well as a certain understanding of reality. This explains why literary works are so important for cultural history.

For any given literary work, its modes of expression reflect the reality perceived by the author or by a particular cultural group centered around the author, thereby revealing certain aspects of social culture. As one of the earliest advocates of zhiguai fiction, *Youyang Zazu* inherits the traditions of Six Dynasties zhiguai literature while also anticipating the interests of Song and Ming supernatural fiction. As a representative work of Tang zhiguai fiction in particular, it occupies a pivotal place in the cultural history of supernatural literature

centered on tales of spirits and anomalies. Moreover, Duan Chengshi's own historiographical inclinations further enhance the historical value of the text.

Overall, the narrative texts and narrative structures of *Youyang Zazu*, when examined through narratological approaches, reveal the cultural orientations of Tang literati—especially those of the middle and late Tang period—as well as broader social values that emphasized engagement with reality, encouraged courage, and promoted resistance against the uncertainties of the world. Thus, as a work of zhiguai fiction, *Youyang Zazu* contains profound cultural significance beneath its supernatural surface.

From a research perspective, however, limitations remain due to the volume of texts and the difficulty of classification. Although this study attempted to narrow its scope as much as possible, there are still areas beyond its reach. While Duan Chengshi himself carried out a certain degree of categorization when compiling the work, the classification of narrative motifs, narrative structures, and story types remains highly challenging. If each narrative text could be systematically categorized according to its narrative structure, it would likely become possible to gain an even deeper understanding of the broader folk-cultural characteristics underlying these stories.

Appendix A

Digital Materials

Public-Facing *Youyang Zazu* Digital Platform (GitHub Repository):

[MoonRiver-echo/youyang-website](https://github.com/MoonRiver-echo/youyang-website)

Public-Facing *Youyang Zazu* Digital Platform (Live Website):

[Youyang Zazu Digital Platform](https://youyangzazu.com)

Digital Assets:

- Image Archive:
[Images Repository](#)
- CSV Dataset Files:
[CSV Analysis Results](#)
- *Youyang Zazu* Data Visualization Repository:
[MoonRiver-echo/youyang-zazu](https://github.com/MoonRiver-echo/youyang-zazu)
- *Youyang Zazu* Data Visualization Front-End Website:
[Youyang Zazu Visualization Platform](https://youyangzazu.com)

Access Requirements:

- Access Permission: Publicly Accessible Repositories
- Contact for technical or access issues: minqianwang@ln.hk

Technical Requirements:

- Modern Web Browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, or Safari recommended)
- Internet connection required for online access
- GitHub account optional for repository interaction

File Formats:

- Dataset Files: CSV format (compatible with Microsoft Excel)
- Image Files: JPG / PNG
- Website Source Code: HTML / CSS / JavaScript
- Data Visualization Resources: CSV / JavaScript / Web-based interactive charts

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